This basic white loaf is soft on the inside, with a light texture. If you have any left the day after you've baked it, use it for croûtons (see p39).

crusty white loaf

MAKES 1 LOAF **PREP** 35 MINS, PLUS RISING **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 6 MONTHS

3 cups bread flour
1½ tsp instant yeast
1¼ tsp salt
1 tsp sugar
1 tbsp vegetable or olive oil
1⅔ cups tepid water, as needed

1 Stir the flour, yeast, salt, and sugar together in a large bowl. Make a well in the center and pour in the oil. Stir in as much of the water as needed to make a soft dough

2 Knead on a lightly floured work surface about 8 minutes, until smooth and elastic. Shape into a ball. Turn into a large oiled bowl, and turn to coat. Cover with plastic wrap. Let stand in a warm place about 1 hour, or until doubled in volume.

3 Oil and flour the inside of a 9 x 5in (23 x 13cm) loaf pan, and tap out the excess flour. Punch down the dough. Shape it into a rough rectangle to fit the pan and place in the pan. Cover with plastic wrap and let stand about 30 minutes, or until almost doubled in volume.

4 Preheat the oven to 425°F (220°C). Dust the top of the loaf with flour. Cut a shallow slash down the center of the loaf. Bake for 20 minutes. Reduce the oven temperature to 400°F (200°C) and bake for 20 minutes more until the loaf sounds hollow when removed from the pan and tapped on the bottom. Transfer to a wire rack and let cool.